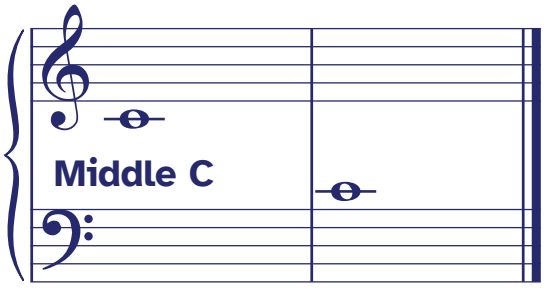
PART I · PITCH · 5

Ledger lines

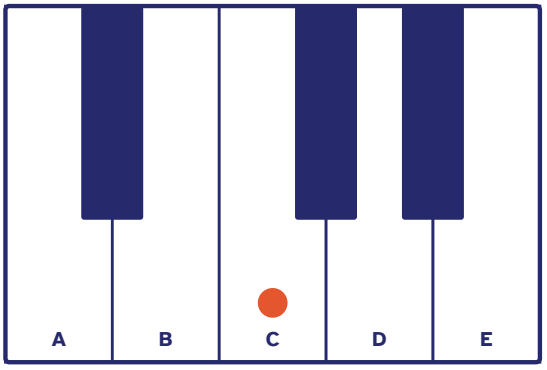
Some notes are too high or too low for the five lines of the staff, so the staff borrows a few short **ledger lines**, spaced just like its own.

THE SECRET

Step out from the nearest staff line: line, space, line. The first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

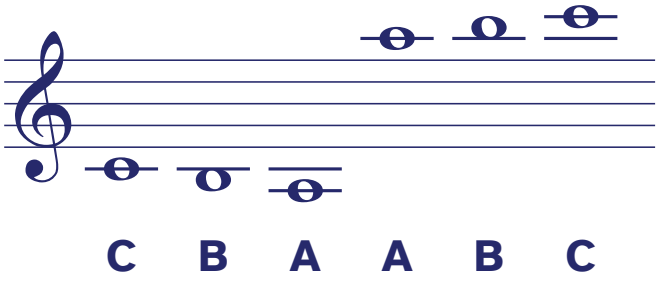


Middle C



Middle C sits on a ledger line of its own: below the treble staff, or above the bass staff. One key, two ways to write it.

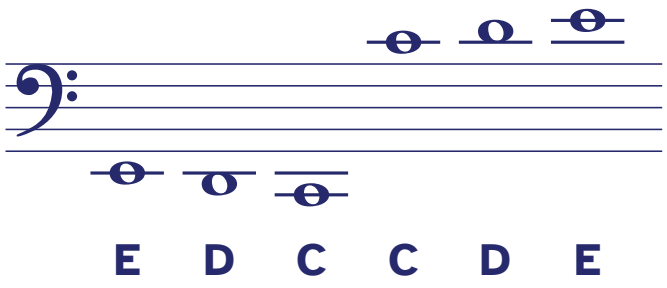
Below and above the staff



Treble: C, B, A below; A, B, C above.

Count ledger lines from the staff outwards: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff. Step out line, space, line, and never skip one.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

EXAMPLE 1

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

EXAMPLE 2

Read a low note on ledger lines



1. **The bottom line** of the bass staff is G.
2. **Step down** one note at a time: F in the space below, E on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: D below it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines below the bass staff: **Low C**, two octaves below Middle C. Its mirror is High C, two ledger lines above the treble.

PART I · PITCH · 5 · CONTINUED

The four first ledger lines



Middle C
treble, below

Middle C
bass, above

A
treble, above
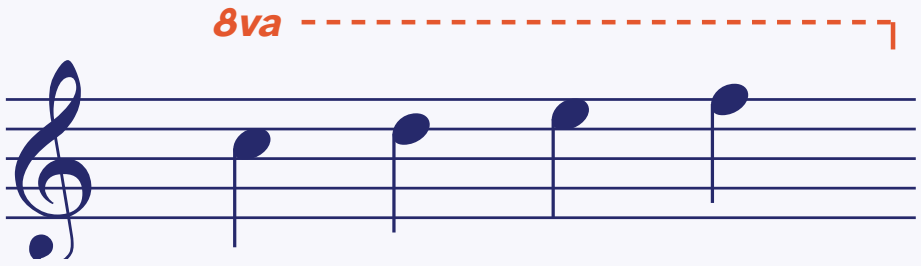
E
bass, below

Only Middle C belongs to both staves.

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Too many ledger lines? 8va

Very high notes need lots of ledger lines, and lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a high passage is often written lower, with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher** (eight notes up, from a C to the next C, p. 25) until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the notes means an octave lower. (On its own, 8ve is just short for octave.)



play these
one octave higher
until the line stops

THINK OF IT Ledger lines are the staff's ladder carried on past its ends: the same rungs, just shorter. Climb them one rung at a time, from the staff outwards, and you can read any note however high or low.

TRAP

- × Reading ledger lines from the wrong end: step out from the staff.
- × Counting from the outside in: the first ledger line is the one nearest the staff.

SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 32 · Sharps, flats and naturals p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Workbook pp. 9–10 · Online: Ledger Lines